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HIS 101: Nigerian History to 1960 - States, Trade and Conquest

Chronology, evidence and the arguments historians actually have

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
History & International Studies | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack gives you the chronology first-year history demands, then shows the arguments behind it: pre-colonial state formation, the trans-Saharan and Atlantic trades, the mechanics of colonial conquest, indirect rule, and the nationalist movement up to independence.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Build a defensible chronology of Nigerian history to 1960.
- Compare pre-colonial political systems without ranking them.
- Explain how colonial administration reshaped economy and society.
- Evaluate competing historical interpretations.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Chronology you must hold

Dates are the skeleton of a history answer.

- Pre-colonial states: Kanem-Bornu, the Hausa city-states, Oyo, Benin, the Igbo segmentary societies.
- Trans-Saharan trade and the spread of Islam in the north.
- Atlantic slave trade and its demographic and political effects.
- Legitimate trade in palm oil and the Niger expeditions.
- Annexation of Lagos (1861) and the Royal Niger Company era.
- Amalgamation of 1914, indirect rule, nationalist parties, and independence in 1960.

Comparing political systems

Comparison needs criteria, not adjectives.

- Centralisation: emperor, oba, emir, or council of elders.
- Succession rules and the role of lineage.
- Taxation, tribute and military organisation.
- Gender and age-grade structures in governance.
- Religion and legitimacy.
- Trade linkages between regions before colonial contact.

> **Avoid the 'stateless' trap**
> Societies without kings were not without government. Describe the institutions that actually governed - councils, age grades, title societies.

Colonial rule and its arguments

Know the debate and its evidence.

- Indirect rule relied on existing authorities and reshaped them in the process.
- Cash crops, rail and taxation integrated Nigeria into an export economy.
- Mission education produced a new elite with its own grievances.
- Nationalism moved from cultural assertion to party politics.
- Historiographical debate: colonial emphasis versus African agency.
- Use primary sources critically: who wrote, for whom, and why?

Before colonial rule: states, trade and networks

Pre-colonial Nigeria contained several distinct political systems. The Sokoto Caliphate, consolidated after the jihad of 1804, was a federation of emirates under a caliph, administered through Islamic law, taxation and a scholarly class. The Oyo Empire governed through a king checked by a council of chiefs, with a cavalry-based military and an elaborate provincial structure. Benin had a centralised monarchy with titled societies and a craft guild system producing the bronzes that later became evidence in debates about African achievement.

Igbo communities are often described as "stateless", which is misleading. Many operated without a central king but through village assemblies, age grades, title societies and oracles that exercised judicial and political authority. The Arochukwu oracle network, for instance, was an economic and legal institution spanning a large region.

Long-distance trade connected these systems: trans-Saharan routes north, Atlantic trade south from the sixteenth century, and internal markets for salt, cloth, iron and kola. The Atlantic slave trade reshaped these economies over three centuries, and its abolition in the nineteenth century drove the expansion of palm oil production - the commodity that made the Niger Delta strategically valuable to Britain.

Conquest, administration and resistance

Colonial rule was established by force and then organised for revenue. The Royal Niger Company governed much of the south before the British government took control in 1900; Lagos was annexed in 1861. The amalgamation of the Northern and Southern Protectorates in 1914 created the administrative entity that became Nigeria, joining regions with different legal systems, religions and fiscal capacities.

The system of administration differed by region. Indirect rule in the north used existing emirate structures, which worked because centralised authority existed. Applied to Igbo communities, it required inventing "warrant chiefs", with consequences that included the Aba Women's War of 1929 - a revolt against taxation and the corruption of warrant chief courts, organised by women through market networks.

Resistance was continuous and varied: military resistance by the Sokoto caliphate and Benin, tax revolts, religious movements, strikes by workers, and nationalist politics. Treating resistance as either absent or uniform misreads the record.

Nationalism to independence

Nationalist organisation developed through newspapers, professional associations, trade unions and students abroad. The National Council of Nigeria and the Cameroons (1944), the Action Group (1951) and the Northern People's Congress (1951) represented different regional and social bases. The constitutions of 1946, 1951, 1954 and 1960 successively expanded elected representation and regional autonomy.

Independence in 1960 was negotiated, not seized. The critical issues were the balance between regions, the status of minorities within them, and control of revenue. The Willink Commission (1957-58) investigated minority fears and declined to create new states, a decision that shaped later conflict.

The historiography matters. Nationalist history emphasised unity and achievement; later scholarship examined class formation, gender, labour and the limits of independence. Reading a source means asking who wrote it, for what audience and what it leaves out - particularly the voices of women, slaves and minorities.

> **Date plus consequence**
> A date alone earns nothing. Write the date, what changed, and who was affected - that is a historical sentence.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Analysing a colonial document

You are given a 1920s district officer's report describing a community as "backward and in need of administration".

1. Establish provenance: author, office, date, purpose of the report.
2. Identify the vocabulary doing ideological work ("backward", "need").
3. Ask what the report is justifying: taxation, labour, intervention.
4. Cross-check against another source: oral testimony, a missionary record, a court case.
5. State what the document can and cannot establish.
6. Note whose voices are absent and how that limits conclusions.

> **What to carry forward**
> Colonial documents are evidence of colonial thinking first and of African life second.

2. Explaining the Aba Women's War

A question asks why the 1929 revolt occurred. Build a causal answer.

1. Immediate trigger: rumours of taxation of women and counting of women and livestock.
2. Structural causes: warrant chiefs, corrupt native courts, loss of women's traditional political roles.
3. Organisation: market networks, women's councils, shared grievance across ethnic lines.
4. Consequences: the colonial administration reformed the warrant chief system and appointed women to some courts.
5. Historiographical point: long described as a "riot"; now understood as organised political action.
6. Conclude that the name matters - it shapes how the event is judged.

> **What to carry forward**
> Give trigger, structure and consequence. Then discuss how the event has been named.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Compare the political organisation of two pre-colonial Nigerian societies.

20 marks

1. Choose systems with real contrast, such as Sokoto and an Igbo community.
2. Compare criteria: authority, law, revenue, military, succession.
3. Explain why the differences arose from scale, ecology and religion.
4. Resist the "centralised equals advanced" assumption.
5. Conclude that both were effective at different scales.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Value-laden language that treats centralised states as superior.

Q2. Why did indirect rule work better in some regions than others?

15 marks

1. Define indirect rule and its fiscal purpose.
2. Explain the fit with emirate structures.
3. Explain the misfit where authority was diffuse, producing warrant chiefs.
4. Give the consequence: Aba Women's War and legitimised grievances.
5. Conclude that administrative systems require existing institutions to work with.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Indirect rule. Colonial administration through existing local authorities under British supervision.

Warrant chief. A chief appointed by colonial administration without traditional legitimacy.

Amalgamation. The 1914 joining of the Northern and Southern Protectorates into one administration.

Sokoto Caliphate. A nineteenth-century Islamic federation of emirates in northern Nigeria.

Aba Women's War. The 1929 revolt by women in eastern Nigeria against taxation and warrant chief courts.

Nationalism. Political movements seeking self-government or independence.

Willink Commission. The 1957-58 inquiry into minority fears before independence, which declined to create new states.

Legitimate trade. Trade in commodities such as palm oil that replaced the slave trade after abolition.

Age grade. An age-based cohort with civic duties and rights.

Historiography. The study of how history has been written and interpreted.

Primary source. Material produced by participants or witnesses of the period studied.

Revenue allocation. The division of public income between levels of government.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Pre-colonial

States and systems.

- Draw a comparison table of three systems.
- Learn two institutions per system.
- Avoid value-laden terms.

Week 2 - Conquest

Administration.

- Map the 1914 amalgamation.
- Explain indirect rule in two regions.
- Build a timeline of resistance events.

Week 3 - Sources

Reading evidence.

- Analyse one colonial document.
- Find one counter-source.
- Write a paragraph on the limits of each.

Week 4 - Nationalism

Argument.

- Timeline of constitutions and parties.
- Explain one minority question.
- Write a timed 20-mark answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A standard history of Nigeria covering the pre-colonial period to 1960.
- Scholarship on the Aba Women's War and colonial administration.
- A historiography introduction explaining nationalist and revisionist approaches.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is 1914 significant in Nigerian history?

Answer: The Northern and Southern Protectorates were amalgamated into a single colonial administration, with consequences for later federal structure.

2. Why is 'stateless society' a misleading term?

Answer: Igbo and similar societies had governance through councils, age grades and title societies rather than a centralised monarchy.

3. What did indirect rule do to traditional authority?

Answer: It used existing authorities for colonial administration while transforming their power, legitimacy and accountability.

4. Name two effects of the Atlantic slave trade on Nigerian societies.

Answer: Population loss and political disruption through raiding; economic reorientation toward slave supply and later legitimate trade.

5. What does African agency mean in historiography?

Answer: Attention to Africans as decision-makers and initiators, not only as respondents to European action.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a dated timeline from 1000 to 1960.
- [ ] Draw a comparison table of three pre-colonial systems.
- [ ] Map trade routes and their commodities.
- [ ] Read one primary source and identify its author's interest.
- [ ] Write an essay plan with a clear thesis.
- [ ] Learn five nationalist figures and their positions.
- [ ] Practise a document question under timed conditions.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: